



Contrastive and Translational Pedagogies for Learning English Idioms: Algerian EFL Learners' Perceptions

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Abstract ;

This study examines the beliefs of Algerian learners of English as a foreign language (EFL) regarding contrastive linguistic or translational linguistics methods for learning expressions in English that are idiomatic in nature. In a mixed methods approach, data were drawn from 120 participants in an online survey and 15 participants in three focus group discussions. The quantitative data indicated strong learner support for first language (L1)-based approaches; 85% indicated that idioms were easier to understand if the teacher explained the idiom in the learner's first language, while 80% indicated that translation made idioms easier to understand. However, only 30% maintained that teachers typically utilized or employed these practices, indicating a gap between learner beliefs and pedagogical practices. The qualitative data supported statements indicating that L1 explanation and contrastive method increased learner recognition, memory, and cultural understanding, while participants also stated that there were limited opportunities to encourage students to be productive in the use of idiomatic expressions. The study identifies a pedagogical potential for EFL teachers to use contrastive and translational methods or approaches in combination to assist EFL learners' understanding of idiomatic expressions in English. Curriculum, teacher preparation, and future research implications for idiomatic expression pedagogies with this multilingual community are put forward.

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1. Introduction

Idiomatic expressions contain some of the most difficult part of learning English as a Foreign Language (EFL). This situation is especially true for learners whose first language (L1) differs largely from English in overall syntactic structures, semantic structure, and cultural references. They are also potentiated obstacles to learners, because they are figurative and non-literal. Indeed, idioms cannot necessarily be understood simply through the combined meaning of their literal words. Idioms exemplify a distinct dilemma with respect to language, cognition, and culture. The experience of interpreting idioms involves figurative (non-literal) thinking and access to common cultural models, which make them a good case study of how learners' home or first language (L1) can work as a resource for mediation rather than a resource for interference. This position aligns well with translanguaging theory which views students' complete linguistic repertoire as dynamic meaning-making resources (García & Wei, 2018; Hall & Cook, 2019). The idioms like “kick the bucket” and “under the weather” often leave the EFL learner unable to come up with a straightforward definition, let alone provide an accurate translation. Retaining and using idioms productively are very difficult as well. The fact that idioms are non-literal expressions of meaning and difficult to memorize means that they remain marginalized in classroom instruction, and if they are taught, idioms often fit into a limited category of a list of memorized idioms without contextualization, meaning, metaphorical quality, or cultural details (Liontas, 2002;

Boers & Lindstromberg, 2008). Nonetheless, idioms are a part of all naturalistic language use, and they are frequently considered socio-linguistic norms, invented perceptions of advanced proficiency and cultural fluency.

More recent shifts in language pedagogy have once again highlighted the potential of the learner's L1 as a cognitive and cultural scaffold. In this current view, two (pedagogical) possibilities for teaching idioms have already been identified: contrastive linguistic analysis (CLA) and translational pedagogy. The first option allows learners to investigate cross-linguistic similarities and differences of both structure and meaning, while the second presents a view of translation as a legitimate meaning-making strategy (rather than an impediment or a crutch). Together these options provide learners with options for decoding and absorbing idiomatic language in ways that they are more familiar with cognitively and culturally. Here, it is important to highlight that (1) it provides learners with ways to compare structure and concepts across languages, (2) it helps learners draw upon expressions embedded culturally in their L1, and (3) it provides a slightly less demanding entry point to ways of abstract or metaphorical meaning through

equivalence-based interpretation (Kövecses, 2010; Cook, 2010; Carreres & Noriega-Sánchez, 2011).

While there is great pedagogical potential in contrastive and translational methodologies, empirical studies documenting their use in the classroom are still rare, especially in North African EFL

contexts. Studies tend to concentrate on theoretical justification, not learner perception or in-class applications (Malmkjaer, 2022). While these, comparison and translational strategies, theories have substantial backing, their practical use in EFL classrooms are limited. Importantly, there is a very limited amount of empirical research specifically focused on how learners view the potencies of contrastive and translational strategies toward the learning of idioms in EFL learning contexts. Specifically, we aren't sure how those strategies influence not just idiom comprehension but also long-term memory and productive use of idioms in both spoken and written forms. This study endeavored to address this gap by investigating learners' beliefs and experiences with contrastive and translational strategies and provide implications about the role the strategies may play in idiomatic uptake. To focus the inquiry, the study will investigate the following research questions: How do EFL learners view the place and role of contrastive linguistic analysis and translational pedagogies in learning English idiomatic expressions? What are some of the positive and negative features that learners mention in using their first language (L1) to assist idiomatic acquisition in the EFL classroom?

2. Literature Review

2.1 English Idiomaticity and EFL Learning

Idiomatic phrases are long-established, crucial images in the use of language, and they represent a unique form of language that strongly contributes to language fluency and cultural appropriateness.

Idioms create continuous challenges for EFL learners, however, because idioms are phrasal combinations that are figurative (non-literal), are culturally grounded, are noncompositional (the idiomatic meaning arises from the combination rather than the individual word meanings), and involve abnormal syntactic structures (Liontas, 2017). For example, idiomatic expressions such as "spill the beans" or "hit the sack" cannot be interpreted literally, as they do not have a literal transparency, meaning these idiomatic expressions violate typical underlying grammatical structures and generally do not have a meshed meaning that gives clues for formal instructions or understanding. The meaning/category of idiomatic expressions cannot be derived from the individual words that compose the idiomatic expression, contributing to a lack of availability to EFL learners who may not have been exposed to the cultural or metaphorical concepts inherent in the idiom. While idiomatic expressions are critical elements of communicative fluency and can be a means of developing pragmatic competence, idiomatic expressions are often either absent or superficially treated in many EFL programs. Idiomatic expressions are often included in EFL programs as a list of decontextualized phrases for either rote memorization or for something like translations of meaning. Current research suggested in formerly education-based literature confirms that limitation. For example, Chen and Lai (2013) discovered that instructional programs on idioms using contextualized, metaphor-based teaching methods produced more retention and productive use than simply learning lists of idioms in isolation. Irujo (2019) echoed

these study findings and emphasized that useful idiom instruction is also dependent on meaningful practice and awareness of the cross-cultural metaphorical conceptions of idioms. These studies provide evidence and support for idiom instruction that links idioms with cognitive and cultural conceptual schemas that learners are accustomed to. This does not promote a depth of idiomatic awareness or productive use of idiomatic expressions.

In response to these limitations, researchers have also suggested seeing idioms as not lexical idiosyncracies but conceptual metaphors derived from culture and cognition. Kövecses (2002) argued that idioms can only be understood by uncovering their underlying metaphorical structures, which reflect embodied experiences shared across or within cultures. Moving forward, cognitive linguists have not only offered accounts of metaphoricity in terms of metaphor awareness, but have also called for pedagogies that embed idioms with larger communicative and cultural contexts. Boers and Lindstromberg (2008) have described a usage-based approach when teaching idioms and recommended that development on idiomatic phrases prioritize metaphor awareness, learning within a context, and a use of visuals or theme-based learning. Primarily, idiomatic phrases should not be taught in isolation, but with real discourse and cultural context that displays how idioms are used in real life. However, such approaches are seldom done in a systematic manner in EFL settings by EFL practitioners; particularly those still follow a grammar syllabus, with the encouragement of exams and

assessment. This leaves open questions on how learners deal with idiomatic language, and how learners could develop idiomatic knowledge given pedagogies that explicitly incorporate contrastive analysis and translation in the instructional process. I believe investigating these pedagogical aspects is crucial to expanding learners' not only fluency, but intercultural communicative awareness of EFL learners.

2.2 Contrastive Analysis and Translational Pedagogies in EFL

Contrastive analysis, originally systematically introduced by Lado (1957), involved the systematic comparison of learners' first language (L1) with the target language that would help predict points of difficulty in second language acquisition. While it was closely associated with the structuralist and behaviorist paradigms of the mid-20th century, contrastive analysis has advanced as pedagogically useful, framed within the cognitive or

communicative approaches to language teaching, and still has a role in helping students recognize structural interference, but also to develop a metalinguistic awareness that is the ability to reflect on the form and function of language. In more recent perspectives, contrastive analysis has shifted from being simply a method for error prediction to a reflective tools for noticing and awareness. That is, according to Larsen-Freeman (2015) and Odlin (2017), a comparison among languages promotes metalinguistic awareness which can lead to learners establishing richer conceptual links between structures, meanings, and cultural references.

Comparisons in this reflective way also go hand in hand with cognitive perspectives linking the use of contrast to the facilitation of long-term memory consolidation. In simple, the role of contrastive analysis, when teaching idioms in particular, is to know the safe distance between English idioms and the learners' L1, and distance requires engaging in comparative reflection of English idioms and instructional idioms in their L1. This facilitates deeper discussion of a comparison of meaning, metaphor, and context. This metalinguistic consideration offers more than linguistic insight, it is also an intercultural awareness that makes idioms less abstract and more understandable (Boers & Lindstromberg, 2008; Kövecses, 2010).

Along with contrastive analysis, translational pedagogy, which has historically taken a backseat to Communicative Language Teaching

(CLT), is resurfacing as a legitimate pedagogical approach to learning. Translation has previously been regarded as an impediment or irrelevant; however, it has been revived as a useful cognitive and cultural tool (particularly beneficial when students share an L1). Cook (2010) has said we ought to not conceptualise the L1 as simply interfering, but that it can be an instrumental resource used to scaffold learner understanding, including when using complex, idiomatic or culturally-bound expressions. Translation is able to close the semantic gap for students by providing varieties of meaning. In more recent times, translation has come to be redefined as an interactive, meaning-

making process, rather than as an unthinking transfer of forms. Both Hall & Cook (2019) and Malmkjaer (2022) contend that using translation in language learning is a means to foster intercultural awareness, noticing, and learner autonomy. When we utilize translation in relation to idioms and other figurative language, we have an opportunity for our students to compare figurative concepts across languages (and cultures) and so explore meaning at a deeper semantic level which may aid retention. In line with this view, Carreres and Noriega-Sánchez (2011) highlight the importance of translation in stimulating learners' awareness of semantic delicacy, cultural awareness, and self-directed learners, which may indicate that well-structured translation tasks do not only enhance language competence at the lexical level or degree of equivalency. While there are a growing number of theoretical experts endorsing the use of translation in language education, there is, however, scant empirical research on learners' perceptions of translational strategies (particularly for idioms). In short, there is a clear gap in the research base on this topic - which is what this study planned to address by looking at how EFL learners had perceived and experienced contrastive and translational strategies in the development of idiomatic competence.

In summary, while the literature provides strong theoretical support for engaging learners' L1 using contrasting and translational strategies, very little empirical research exists that investigates EFL learners' perceptions of these strategies in their own classroom experiences. This study attempts to address this gap by

looking at Algerian learners' perspectives on the cognitive and pedagogical affordances of these approaches to learn idioms.

3. Methodology

3.1 Research Design

The present study used a qualitative-dominant mixed-methods design (Creswell & Plano Clark, 2018) to investigate learners' perceptions of contrastive and translational pedagogies in their learning of idioms. A mixed-methods approach was selected to draw on the advantages of quantitative survey data to provide breadth of investigation and qualitative focus group data to provide depth of investigation thereby increasing validity through triangulation.

Using a qualitative-dominant mixed-methods design, this study employed quantitative and qualitative instruments to gather data on EFL learners' perceptions of using contrastive linguistic analysis and translational pedagogies in learning English idiomatic expressions. The research took place in two phases, starting with a structured questionnaire that was administered to a heterogeneous sample of learners from several Algerian universities to map overall patterns in learners' attitudes, their strategy choices, and classroom experiences of idiom learning. To enhance and illuminate the findings, an online focus group discussion was also conducted with learners, whereby they could explicate their views in oral form to uncover some contextualized interpretations and meanings about their

learning journeys and classroom experiences.

This mixed-methods approach was selected not only for its ability to triangulate data but also for its ability to combine breadth and depth in the quantitative phase, we acquired generalizable trends, while the qualitative approach provided rich and nuanced narrative accounts of individual learner perspectives. This approach meshed well with Creswell and Plano Clark's (2018) recommendation for qualitative-dominant designs where researchers examine the learner experience within the sociocultural context and while learners are making sense of their interpretive meaning-making processes. Additionally, using the methods together allowed the study to reflect the diversity of learners' backgrounds,

available language proficiency, and the level of exposure to idiomatic instruction in different institutional contexts. Balancing broader empirical trends and the learner voice ensured the methodology illustrated a fully situated understanding of how contrastive and translational strategies were in evidence in actual educational contexts, linking together prevalent macro-level trends with micro-level lived experiences.

The design was explanatory sequential, starting with a descriptive phase to find trends, followed by a qualitative phase which would describe and explain the findings in context.

3.2 Participants

Participants were undergraduate students in English from a variety of Algerian universities. Invitations were distributed to some 200 potential participants via institutional mailing lists and student forums, with 120 valid responses (response rate = 60%). All participants had completed a minimum of two years of university-level English courses and participants were all familiar with idiomatic expressions from class. Inclusion criteria for indicatives was a minimum of intermediate level (self-reported B1 or greater) and consent to participate voluntarily. No incentives were provided. A total of 120 EFL learners completed the online questionnaire while 15 students participated in 3 online focus group discussions (5 students per group). The focus group participants were purposefully chosen from the questionnaire respondents to vary in gender, university background, and self-rated English proficiency, thus ensuring representation from multiple academic contexts in Algeria.

The participants were selected through purposeful sampling, with all of the participants having at least intermediate English skills and previous exposure to idiom learning in class. The invitations were electronically circulated using academic mailing lists and student forums. Participation was voluntary and informed consent was obtained from all participants.

3.3 Data Collection Tools

3.3.1. Online Questionnaire

A structured questionnaire was developed with Google forms and disseminated as a digital survey. The survey included Likert-scale items, multiple-choice questions, and optional short-answer questions with a primary focus on learners' engagement

with idiomatic expressions, awareness of contrastive illustrations, and attitudes towards the use of their first language (L1) during idiomatic instruction. A small pilot study was conducted using a small group of students to check the clarity and content validity of the items. Reliability and internal consistency were analyzed using Cronbach's alpha ($\alpha = .83$), which indicated that the scale items with a Likert scale had good reliability. Content validity was obtained through expert examination by two applied linguistics lecturers who assessed the questionnaire for clarity, coverage, and relevance of the items. Ultimately, the final version contained 20 items representing three domains: learner attitudes toward idioms, forms of contrastive and translational strategies, and confidence in idiom use.

3.3.2. Online Focus Groups

Three online focus group discussions were held via Zoom, each taking 45-60 minutes. Participants were put into small groups for engagement; each focus group was facilitated with 5 to 7 learners (still together as they had already completed the first questionnaire). The discussions were guided by a semi-structured protocol to allow for open reflection on participants' experiences with acquiring idioms. The protocol included several key prompts that engaged learners with such questions as: How often did you find idiomatic expressions in the material? What did you think about the process of learning through cross-linguistic comparison? And did you find translation to be a useful strategy in lessons in class. The semi-structured protocol provided a consistent structure to the group discussions while still allowing

flexibility across groups, so participants could expand on ideas and share their own experiences, which facilitated some back-and-forth responses.

All sessions were conducted in the language of English so that the language-learning focus of the study reflected authentic insight into the linguistic knowledge, understanding, and metacognitive awareness of learners. Informed consent was gathered prior to sessions, and participants were assured of the confidentiality of their involvement. Each session was audio recorded upon approval, and then transcription and anonymization was carried out during the data processing. The transcripts then also went through thematic analysis so that patterns of recurrence and participant uniqueness could surface across the datasets. This qualitative piece provided rich, contextualized insight of the ways learners worked with idioms in real learning spaces and how they were interpreting contrastive and translational techniques as part of their educational experience. The data from focus group sessions, which comprised a combination of individual behaviour and social interaction were clearly crucial for developing the description of learner attitudes and for using the questionnaire results in a triangulated manner.

3.4 Data Analysis

The data analysis took place in two stages according to the mixed-methods design. The quantitative data from the questionnaire were analyzed in with SPSS v.27 and the qualitative transcripts of the interviews underwent a thematic coding

using NVivo 14, to ensure that data was treated systematically. Descriptive statistics (frequencies and percentages) were used to summarize the questionnaire results and identify general patterns in learner perceptions. Thematic analysis of the transcripts from the focus groups was performed according to Braun and Clarke's (2006) six-step process to organize and interpret qualitative data. Codes were generated in an inductive manner and grouped under overarching themes the related learners' beliefs, benefits, challenges, and preferences related to idiomaticity and instructional approaches. When applicable, inferential tests including independent-sample t-tests and chi-square analyses examined group differences by gender and proficiency level. Statistical significance was established at $p < .05$. For reader transparency, the quantitative and qualitative datasets, represented anonymized, will be shared upon request provided the request is reasonable.

3.4 Ethical Considerations

Ethical approval for this study was obtained from the Research Ethics Committee at the University Center of Barika. All participants provided informed digital consent before data collection. Participants were assured informed of their anonymity, and confidentiality rights, as well as the ability to withdraw at any time without penalty. All electronic files (survey responses, recordings, transcripts) were password-protected and securely stored on the university's research drive.

4. Findings

This section will provide the main findings obtained from the questionnaire and online focus group discussions conducted with Algerian EFL learners. The data provides

commonly held learner attitudes toward the use of contrastive analysis and translation, in acquiring English idioms, highlighting potential advantages of L1-based strategies, as well as the limitations with these pedagogical practices. Quantitative

findings are provided with descriptive statistics (mean and standard deviation) and percentage distributions of agreement to assess the level and direction of learner responses, while qualitative findings will be organized thematically to provide additional richness and context.

4.1 Questionnaire Findings

The questionnaire methodology sought to investigate EFL learner attitudes toward contrastive analysis and translational pedagogies in their learning of English idioms. Five main Likert-scale items were investigated using descriptive statistics (mean and standard deviation) and percentage distributions of agreement to evaluate the level and direction of learner responses.

Data from 120 valid surveys were examined using SPSS version 27. Descriptive statistics (means, standard deviations, percentages) were calculated for each item, followed by inferential tests to determine differences among gender and self-rated proficiency levels (Intermediate vs. Advanced).

Table 1. Learners' Responses to Idiom Instruction Statements

Note: Mean scores based on a 5-point Likert scale (1 = Strongly Disagree, 5 = Strongly Agree).

Statement	Mean (M)	SD	% Agree/Strongly	% Neutral	% Disagree/Strongly Disagree
Idioms are easier to understand when explained in L1	4.25	0.78	85%	10%	5%
Contrastive analysis helps me remember idioms	4.10	0.81	78%	15%	7%
Translation improves my understanding of idioms	4.12	0.76	80%	12%	8%
I feel confident using idioms in writing	3.08	1.15	42%	28%	30%
Teachers often use contrastive methods in class	2.78	1.14	30%	30%	40%

	Agree				
Idioms are easier to understand when explained in L1	4.25	0.78	85%	10%	5%
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I feel confident using idioms in writing	3.08	1.15	42%	28%	30%
Teachers often use contrastive methods in class	2.78	1.14	30%	30%	40%

The table above demonstrates the following key points:

a. Strong Learner Support for L1-Mediated Idiom Instruction

The strongest-rated item was "Idioms are easier to understand when explained in L1" with a mean of 4.25, and 85% of respondents selecting, "Agree" or "Strongly Agree." This represents a strong learner belief that first language scaffolding improves their ability to process figurative expressions. The relatively low standard deviation (SD = 0.78) represents the agreement across participants.

These results have been endorsed by Boers and Lindstromberg (2008) who note that L1 can facilitate richer metaphorical processing by eliminating some of the

cognitive burdens often associated with processing opaque idioms.

b. Contrastive Analysis as a Memory Aid

Learners also indicated their strong levels of agreement on the benefits of contrastive linguistic strategies. The presented item, "Contrastive analysis helps me remember idioms" received a mean of 4.10 and 78% of respondents stated they "Agree" or "Strongly Agree". Respondents reported that seeing how English idioms compared to Arabic or French served to reinforce their understanding and aided long-term retention of the idiom.

This supports existing pedagogical literature which argues for the use of contrastive analysis in order to raise figurative language awareness and to activate conceptual metaphor frameworks (Kövecses, 2010).

c. Translation as a Cognitive Support Strategy

The item "Translation improves my understanding of idioms" had a mean score of 4.12, with 80% of students agreed that using translation aided their understandings. These results attest to the argument that translation, when used intentionally, is neither harmful and can be viewed as a significant pedagogical bridge; an approach that can amplify the learners' understanding of idioms that may be culturally distant or metaphorically opaque. For example, idiomatic expressions like "spill the beans" or "kick

the bucket" were relatively easy to paraphrase when triangulating the Arabic or French equivalents, or were translated literally and then explained.

d. Confidence in Idiom Use Remains Limited

Although students expressed positive perspectives on the comprehension

strategies, only 42% of students expressed confidence in using idioms when writing. The item "I feel confident using idioms in writing" had a mean of 3.08, with a high standard deviation of 1.15; that is, there were mixed results for this item. Therefore, many learners remain unsure about how to use idioms productively; possibly due to fear of misusing idioms or limited opportunities to practice in an academic context.

This practice gap between receptive knowledge and productive use is consistent with research on idiomatic competence (Liontas, 2002), which explains that instruction does not guarantee use unless it is continually reinforced through authentic communicative experiences.

e. Instructional Gaps in Classroom Practice

The last statement "Teachers use contrastive methods in class sometimes" produced the lowest mean (2.78) and the highest rate of disagreement (40%). Only 30% of learners agreed that these methods were regular practices in their classrooms, further indicating instructional misalignment. Although students value the contrastive and translation approaches, they are currently not a formally adopted part of EFL teaching practice. Such a difference indicates the need for improvements to training practices for EFL teachers and curriculum development that honors learners' preferences and theorizes them into the teaching of figurative language.

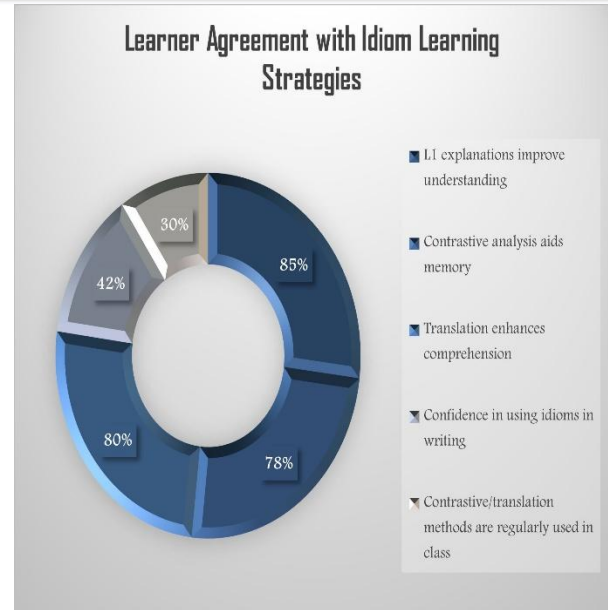
Independent- sample t-tests were used to detect significant differences between male

and female learners as well as between the two proficiency levels (i.e., intermediate and advanced). The findings revealed no significant differences in gender based on the five items ($p > .05$). However, the differences between writers in the intermediate group ($M = 2.91$, $SD = 1.14$) and writers in the advanced group ($M = 3.48$, $SD = 1.02$) on item 2 (i.e. Confident Idioms Item), was significant $t(118) = 2.62$, $p = .01$. The advanced learners in this group had significantly more confidence than those in the intermediate group in using idioms in writing. This may suggest that even greater language proficiency was slightly correlated with greater comfort with idioms as a productive language task. The following pie chart represents the proportions of learners who agreed or strongly agreed with five statements related to idiom learning strategies. In addition, it demonstrated visually that a clear preference for L1-based and contrastive methods existed in the learning preferences by Algerian EFL learners.

Fig.1. Learner Agreement with Idiom Learning Strategies

Percentages represent the proportion of respondents who selected "Agree" or "Strongly Agree" for each statement.

The visual distribution presented in Figure 1 confirms a clear learner preference for L1-based explanation and contrastive comparison. The large percentage of agreement across the first three items reflects a consistent trend observed in the descriptive analysis, reinforcing the cognitive and affective value learners place on translation and cross-linguistic reflection.



The largest section (85%) related to the belief that idioms are easier to understand when it is explained in their first language. This affirms the cognitive advantage learners perceive from L1 scaffolding when the idiom is opaque culturally or metaphorically.

Following this were the 80% of respondents who believed translation is also beneficial for comprehension, thus supporting the notion that bilingual mediation is still a valuable practice in idiom instruction. Another 78% of learners considered contrastive analysis as a suitable strategy to memorize idioms, also highlighting that making cross-linguistic similarities explicit was useful.

In a contrast, only 42% of participants expressed confidence regarding using idioms in writing, indicating a gap between comprehension and productive use. In regard to using contrastive methods in class, only 30% of participants confirmed this occurs regularly in their learning process, suggesting a discrepancy between the students' preferred modes of learning

and what currently happens in the classroom.

4.2 Focus Group Findings

To add a contextual layer to the statistical trends, three focus group discussions were thematically analyzed qualitatively. The next section will present learners' collective views and experiences, demonstrating how L1-based and contrastive strategies operated in practice.

The rich, contextualized focus group data provided insight into how Algerian EFL learners interacted with English idioms, while utilizing their native linguistic and cultural understandings. Thematic analysis revealed three consistent themes of learner concern and understanding:

1. Theme 1. L1 as a Cognitive Anchor for Idiom Comprehension
2. Theme 2. Contrastive Analysis Supports Memory and Cultural Insight
3. Theme 3. Lack of Structured Idiom Instruction in the Classroom

a. L1 as a Cognitive Anchor for Idiom Comprehension

A notable theme that was evident in all focus groups was the strategic use of learners' L1, Arabic primarily, and at times, French, as a cognitive anchor to understand idiomatic expressions in English. Learners noticed that when they experienced idioms in English without being shown L1 equivalents or no culturally familiar explanation, they often struggled to understand the idioms or misinterpreted them. The abstract and figurative nature of idioms presented a challenge particularly when taught without context or explained using only L2 vocabulary.

Many learners shared idioms that confused them initially. One participant described the experience: "When I first saw 'hit the sack' I was confused, thinking it was violent or maybe an insult. But then when the teacher told us it means 'to go to sleep' and translated it, 'أرتمى في الفراش'—it literally made sense at that moment." Another learner remarked, "Idioms do not make sense, word by word. I always want to hear an Arabic version first, otherwise I just memorize them without knowing what it means." In addition to hit the sack, similar feedback was given regarding other idioms, such as "under the weather" and "bite the bullet," which all made more sense when there was a culturally relevant equivalent, or narrative explanation, provided in learners' L1.

This evidence from learners supports the quantitative finding that 85% of learners who completed the questionnaire said that idioms were easier to understand when explained in their L1. Ideally, learners were able to work with their L1 explanations provided by educators, which gave them a mental 'hook' to hang onto the abstract meaning of idioms, helping short-term comprehension and long-term memory. One learner summarized this nicely, "If I can attach an idiom to a similar Arabic phrase, or idea, I will never forget it."

this theme supports the cognitive value of the L1 in the process of idiom acquisition and contradicts the idea that first-language use in the EFL classroom gets in the way of learning. On the contrary, for many students, it serves as a critical interpretive device when navigating the conceptual

divide between literal form and figurative meaning.

b. Contrastive Analysis Supports Memory and Cultural Insight

The second theme centered on the use of contrastive analysis, actively comparing English idioms with equivalent or similar expressions in Arabic or French. Students found that this method not only helped them retain idiomatic expressions but also sparked interest in cultural nuance.

For example, when sensing the idiom "spill the beans", learners explained that the equivalent Arabic expression "يفشي السر" (to reveal a secret), helped them recall the metaphorical meaning of the idiom. Another learner explained:

"I will never forget 'when pigs fly' because in Arabic we say 'في المشمش', they are both used for impossible things, but in a funny way. That comparing image stays in my mind."

In another example, a learner illustrated how contrastive analysis clarified idioms like "cost an arm and a leg" by comparing it with the Arabic "بثمن غالٍ" or "كلفه الكثير". The equivalence of body parts versus the abstract value of the cost helped the learners reflect on how both English and Arabic think about the conceptualization of meaning differently.

These examples are indicative of the 78% of the survey participants who agreed that contrastive analysis contributed to idiom recall and understanding.

c. Lack of Structured Idiom Instruction in the Classroom

Despite these preferences, learners interviewed indicated that idioms were often not addressed, or were only superficially covered in their formally designed coursework. Many learners

reported that of the idiomatic language encountered, it was introduced in a more random, spontaneous way, often times without enough explanation or revision for retention.

One participant said: "In the literature classes where we are exposed to idioms, they are often not explained. We just guess from the context, or we look them up ourselves." Another said: "If we had idiom lessons, where we received English idioms compared to Arabic or French idioms, we could use them when we write or speak. But it's not in the program." Others mentioned that although certain teachers put effort into explaining idioms or translated them, this remains largely dependent on each individual's initiative, not systematically integrated into their curriculum. One student captured this neatly: "It depends on the teacher. Some are capable of giving examples and using Arabic. Most don't consider idioms at all." This qualitative view reflects the questionnaire data, where only 30% of learners agreed that teachers were using contrastive strategies regularly in class.

Ultimately, the focus group results added strength to the survey findings: Algerian EFL learners highly value idiom instruction that incorporates L1 explanation and contrastive analysis. These approaches help comprehension, long-term retention, and incite intercultural awareness. Unfortunately, these efforts are not consistent with the intended practice, which reflects a tension between learners' needs and what teachers impart in instruction. The results demonstrate a pressing need to present idiom instruction in a systematic way that is culturally relevant to students in EFL contexts.

In summary, the qualitative findings support the quantitative results, revealing that learners conservatively consider their L1 as a support for understanding idiomatic meaning. Both results indicate a significant preference for and with contrastive and translational approaches, as well as frustration at their limited implementation in the classroom context. The similarities in findings enhance the validity of the claims made about learner needs and the alignment of their needs with pedagogy.

5. Discussion

This discussion aims to make sense of the main conclusions of the study in light of past research and theoretical frameworks. The results demonstrated a strong learner preference for L1-based explanation, L1 translation, and L1/target language contrastive comparison to learn idiomatic expressions. These findings align with earlier work that emphasizes the cognitive and cultural function of the first language when understanding figurative language (Boers & Lindstromberg, 2008; Cook, 2010; García & Wei, 2018). The discussion below contextualizes these findings, and discusses their pedagogical implications, and also provides a few limitations of the study, as well as future directions for research.

This study provides persuasive evidence that contrastive linguistic analysis and interpretation strategies are among the aid resources available to optimize Algerian EFL learners' comprehension and retention of English idioms. The participants reflected on idioms becoming much clearer and more memorable when explained using equivalent L1 expressions in Arabic or French. These results are in accordance

with cognitive linguistic theories arguing that idioms are best processed not as isolated lexical items, but as metaphorical concepts that are shaped through our embodied experience and through cross-linguistically situated mappings (Kövecses, 2010). When learners encountered idioms in L2 such as "kick the bucket" or "let the cat out of the bag," and were able to correlate them to culturally familiar L1 phrases, their overall comprehension of the idioms increased along with their confidence. Thus, as Boers and Lindstromberg (2008) suggest, idiosyncratic domineering metaphors that are shared across languages enhance figurative competence because they lessen cognitive load while promoting retention. Furthermore, the students' comments support Charteris-Black's (2002) claim that dealing with contrastive metaphoric analysis can homogenize figurative competence through cross-cultural metaphoric concepts.

Nevertheless, this study also points out the mismatch between the ways learners naturally found convenient and the common practices found in EFL classrooms. Despite the majority of participants supporting the idea of L1-based explanations, as well as contrastive methods, those engaging in classes utilizing this instruction were in the minority. This hints that current, still prevailing pedagogical priorities are driven by an ideology to remain monolingual and target language exclusive, despite ample evidence that deploying L1 strategically can deepen understanding, most especially with more complex figurative sample language. While the learners showing comprehension of the idioms, when

bolstered with contrastive input, relayed many expressed hesitancy, reluctance, or uncertainties in the productive use of idioms, and particularly when writing. The gap between comprehension and production reflects the observations of Liontas (2002) who found that idiom knowledge is typically passive and transfer-oriented, unless tasks directing production are assigned. Liao (2006) further observed that faced with a complication of language, learners often rely on translation as a personal strategy, but derivatively few pedagogically based efforts are focusing learners purposefully toward translation. So, as the implications of the current work indicate, any future pedagogically directed contrastive and translational approach to idiom instruction can be made more legitimate and systematic for the importance of idiomatic knowledge, especially in our multilingual contexts such as Algeria, where a learners L1 can commonly be a bridge, not a barrier to idiomatic acquisition.

The findings from both stages of this study indicate a substantial difference between learner needs and instructional practices regarding idiomatic expression in the EFL classroom. Idioms are untapped resources language practitioners can utilize to support learning because, while they are often thought of as markers of advanced language skills and cultural fluency, they do indeed remain under focussed in Algeria's English programming. Idioms are often taught as a list to memorize, devoid of any context or explanation. The learners in this study were particularly strong about the cognitive and cultural merit of connecting (or bridging) their L1 to be able to grasp figurative meaning. This work

echoes researchers' recommendations to use translanguaging and the L1 to be able to deepen understanding and therefore linguistic confidence when using items of abstract language, such as idioms (Cook, 2010; Carreres & Noriega-Sánchez, 2011). Moreover, the students' reflections showed that idioms change from a vague meaning, or no meaning at all, to being meaningful and therefore better retained when translated into their L1, contextualized, and attempted contrasts on idiomatic expressions from their cultures.

As a consequence of these findings, the present study suggests a rethinking of the approach to idioms within EFL classrooms. First, idioms should be taken as contrastive analysis and translation exercises that can be seen as pedagogically advantageous rather than being treated with avoidance under monolingual or immersion ideologies. The more foregrounded, aware the teacher can be in guiding students from their L1 into English idioms with pedagogical tasks allowing learners to make cognitively useful cross-linguistic mappings through metaphor awareness and usage-based contexts, the better the learner will use and retain their meaning. The potential for authentic materials, such as idioms in film dialogues, social media, or narratives to further student interest and engagement with L1 equivalents included, is quite substantial. The research could also explore ways in which contrastive and translational techniques could be scaffolded with increasing complexity and sophistication along proficiency levels, and how to facilitate student learners' active use, not just their passive comprehension, of idioms. This study has illustrated the unexplored opportunities for learner-

centered, linguistically conscious and agentic pedagogies that deliberately develop an idiomatic competence, and as such, it advocates for a more locally knowledgeable, culturally responsive, and balanced approach to teaching figurative language in multilingual EFL contexts.

In practice, EFL teachers might include brief bilingual activities (such as by completing idiom matching tasks, guided translation journals, or contrastive metaphor analysis). For example, learners might find equivalents between English and Arabic idioms, address cultural points, and produce brief conversations using idioms. Such tasks would support comprehension as well as begin to push learners toward producing idioms. Teacher training programs must similarly incorporate how to strategically use L1 and move away from "English-only" concepts, which are outdated.

5.2 Limitations and Future Research

Even if they provide useful information about learners' perceptions and views, the study had some limitations. First, it relied solely on self-reported data. No direct observations of classroom behavior or assessments of actual learning were conducted. Second, although the sample was diverse, it came from a limited set of Algerian universities, so the findings cannot be expanded to EFL learners more generally. With this limitations in mind, future studies could minimize these limitations with experimental or longitudinal for idiom acquisition measures. Future studies could also triangulate their data between learners and teachers, and/or compare multiple learners with different L1 backgrounds. Overall, this would help establish whether the

learners' perceived benefits can be connected to meaningful idiomatic competence.

6. CONCLUSION

This empirical evidence supports the claim that both contrastive analysis and translation provide valuable scaffolding for Algerian EFL learners to acquire English idiomatic expressions. Both quantitative and qualitative data confirmed that learners are successful using L1-based strategies, and L1 strategies are particularly useful for processing culturally opaque idioms. Making comparisons between English idioms and idioms in Arabic or French provided learners with a solid point of departure for clarifying meaning and enhancing retention, consistent with earlier studies in the area of cognitive linguistics (Boers & Lindstromberg, 2008; Kövecses, 2010). That being said, L1-based strategies remain underutilized in classroom practice, with many learners reporting they had inconsistent or no exposures to idioms through contrastive or translational methods.

The findings of this study indicate clear pedagogical implications. Teachers should consider implementing contrastive explanation and in some instances translation into idiom instruction in a more systematic way. Idioms associated modules should be included into the curriculum, and should facilitate both recognition and production of idioms, supported by class tasks such as writing, story-telling, and speaking within the context. Such approaches bridge the gap between passively comprehending idioms and actively using them in conversation.

With those considerations in mind, the study has its limitations. The data was

collected from only learners and involved learner self-reported perceptions rather than relying on classroom observations or educator input. Additionally, while participants came from diverse universities, the findings are context-bound cannot be generalized to other contexts. Future research has the potential to be more expansive in scope, examining the role of teacher training, classroom observations of idiom instruction in real time, and comparisons of learners across a variety of contexts or even across different L1s. Longitudinal studies could be utilized to determine whether consistent exposure to contrastive idiom instruction develops better idiomatic competence in the long run.

In a multilingual EFL context such as Algeria, it is not only pedagogically sound to legitimate the learners' L1 as a resource for becoming proficient with other sophisticated figurative language, it is imperative for both deeper culturally-oriented understanding, and communication competence.

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